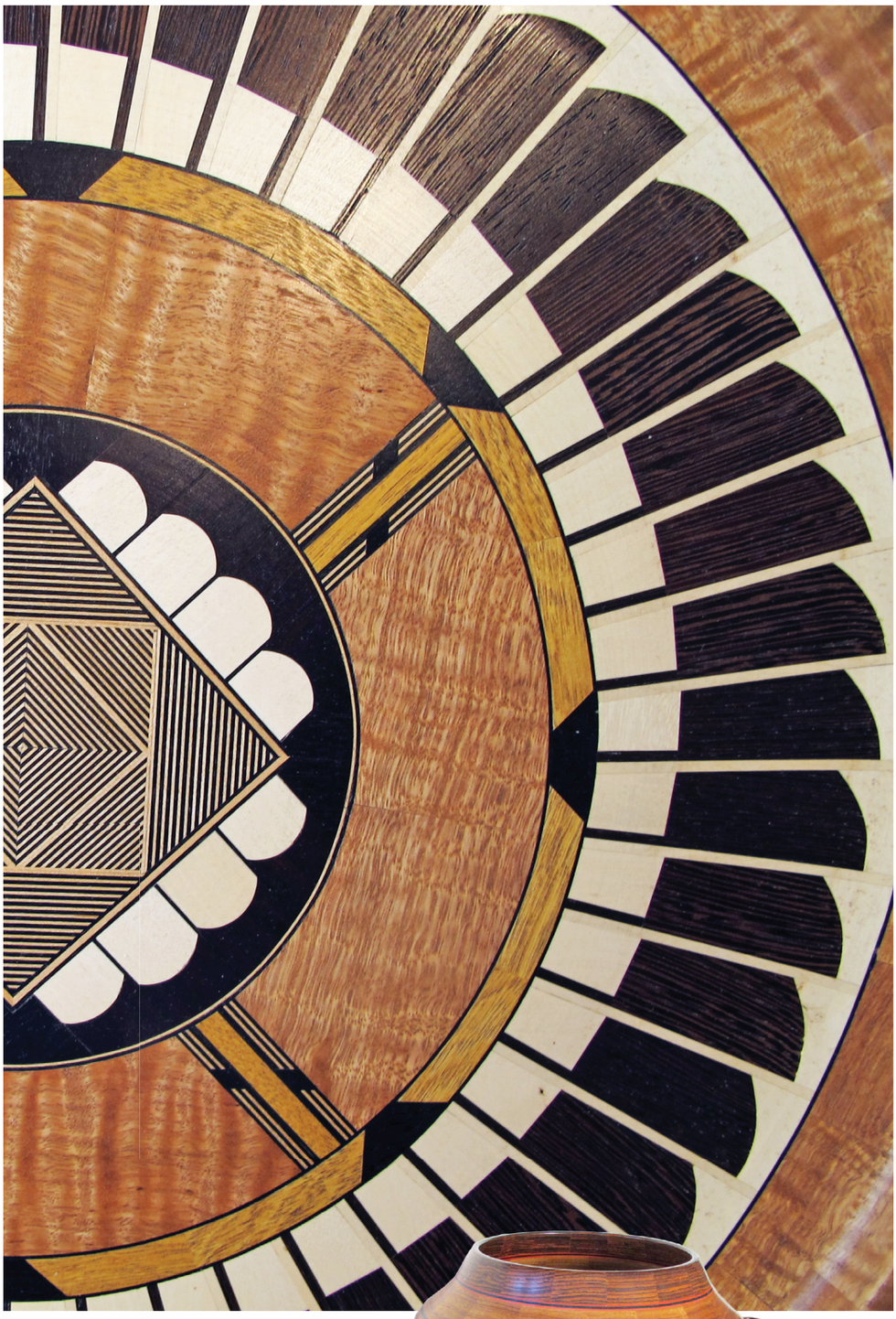

Turning style

Most of Nelson's pieces are simple classical forms such as vessels and plates. Where he separates himself from the average turner is in his segmented designs. Over the years his work has evolved from simplistic designs with fewer than 50 pieces for a vessel in a symmetrical pattern to unique and abstract designs with over 3,000 pieces. Nelson describes the style of his work as "Patient, perfect, intricate, delicate, unique, creative, beautiful."

He spends between eight and 10 hours a day in his workshop. His more complicated pieces, such as 'Lifesaver' and 'Faces' can take over 500 hours to complete, while other projects, including the bangles, can be done in two or three days.

Workshop and tools

Nelson works from a custom-built converted two-car garage with all the amenities of convenience. The style of his work means that he relies on his sander a lot: "When I cut a small intricate piece I have to finish the edges perfectly so that the design is perfect and the glue holds firm. I create special jigs to simplify this process. My Easywood tool has become my favourite tool for general turning."

Future plans

When asked where he sees his work heading, Nelson chuckles as he says he is working on a design for his personal urn to put his ashes in! Other plans include "Completing my new designs and creating some never-seen-before looks."

Highs and lows of turning

Teaching the young turners at the Utah Symposium has been a real high for Nelson. He was also very excited when he sold 'Lifesaver' for $10,000, few artists can claim such good fortune. His low has been his degenerating eyes and health. When asked what he thinks is the best thing about turning, he says "I keep coming up with new ideas, the possibilities are endless and it excites me every day."

LEFT: Multiple examples of Nelson's bangles and small vessels

LIKES

- The challenge, the creativity, the multiple possibilities

DISLIKES

- The sawdust

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